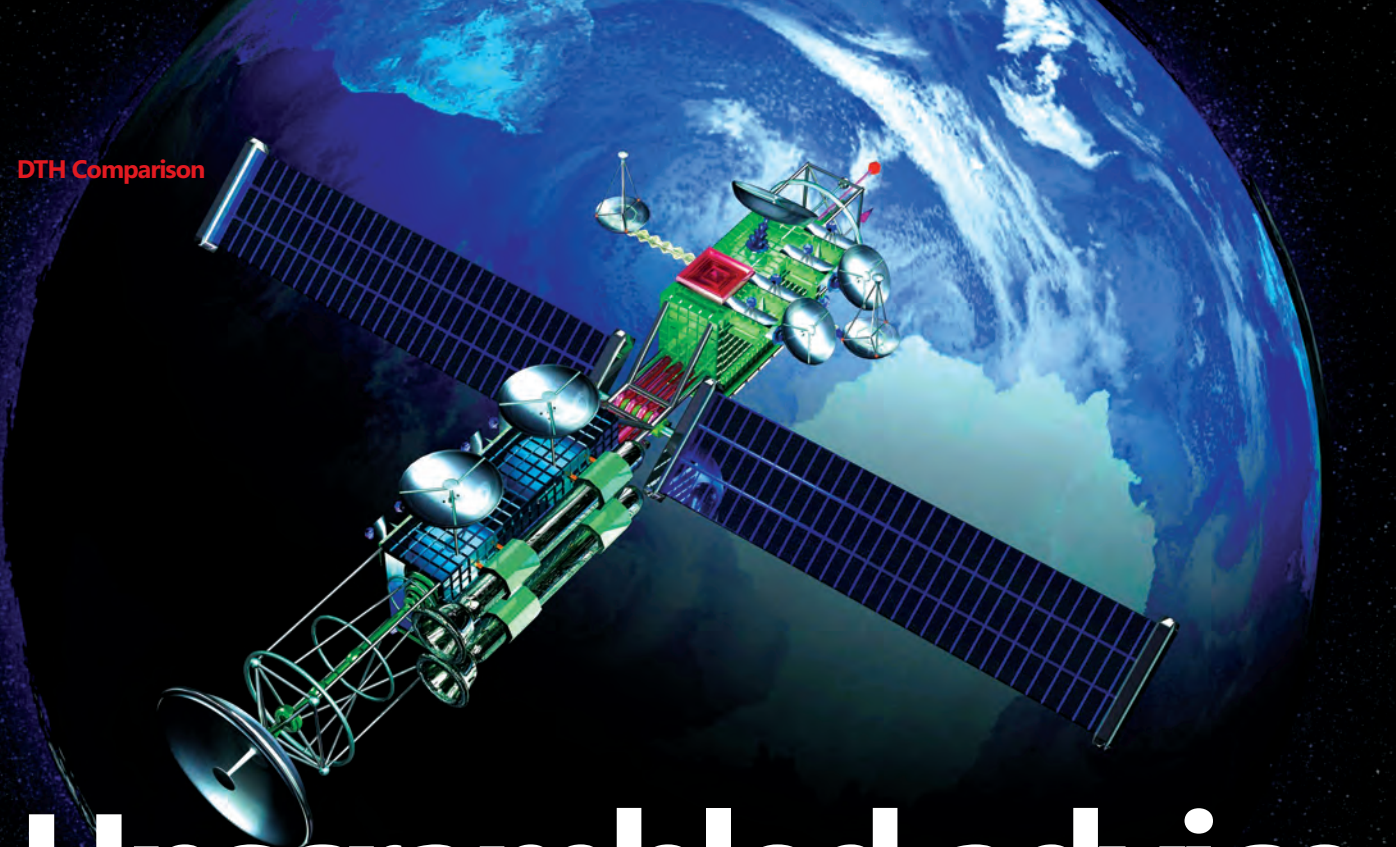




Unscrambled advice

With so many DTH operators vying for your attention, how do you choose?

Recently, in some areas of Mumbai, customers have a choice when it comes to basic utility service providers. Even when it comes to their electric supply, which has for long been public sector controlled, consumers can now choose between two providers, and many are exercising that new found freedom. So when it comes to cable TV entertainment, naturally we will tend to be more picky. With several new entrants in the market, the already crowded Direct To Home (DTH) space now has more than enough contenders; namely, Dish TV, TataSky, BigTV, Airtel Digital, Sun Direct and Videocon d2h. The battle is getting fierce, while the consumer is spoilt for choice. Who's complaining?

More choice means more confusion. So many players, so many packages, so many plans – how does one choose? It's so overwhelming some-

times, that we wouldn't mind hiring a consultant to spew out a solution suited for our needs. There are various factors one needs to consider when making a choice about DTH providers. First, there is the question of whether a cable set-top box is sufficient for you. Next, when you've decided to go in for DTH, there are various factors one needs to consider like picture quality, transmission during rough weather, how suitable are the package bouquets, pricing, and, of course, value added services.

Since the services are dependent on signal strength, geographical variances have to be considered. If a particular provider has excellent reception in one area it may not necessarily be the same elsewhere.

When it comes to choosing DTH providers, some go strictly by price – the cheapest being the default winner. But most people go by what their friends and relatives have to say. We

asked the Digit reader community what they felt about the various players out there. We conducted an online survey where we asked readers to rate their DTH service on each of the parameters mentioned. But before we get to them, let's iron out some of the basics.

The DTH story

DTH can be defined simply as the transmission mode by which satellite TV programming can be received at home. It began in India, a few years ago, with Dish TV who was awarded the country's first DTH licence in 2003 and began operations in 2004. DTH is the primary alternative if you don't want to depend on local cable operators, who, let's face it, have a lot of problems when it comes to service delivery. Tier 2 and 3 towns frequently face Cable TV outages and breakdowns and service is not dependable. Since DTH signals come directly from the broad-

cast satellite to the consumer's dish, it can reach remote places. With the widespread implementation of CAS (Conditional Access System) throughout the country, DTH is a good alternative. As of now, there are primarily six main players in this space with Videocon being the youngest entrant. Each player has more popularity in certain zones. For instance, Sun with its bouquet of south Indian channels is strong in the south. As of late 2008, Dish TV had about 59 per cent market share followed by TataSky. But within three months of its launch, Reliance BIG TV gained 15 per cent of the share.

Key parameters

In the current scenario, DTH players are offering a host of services to attract consumer attention. Here are some of the features you should consider before you decide which service provider you would opt for, from the ever growing list.